Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ Q 10 9 3 ♦ A J 10 7 ♣ A 8	
♠ 10 9 7 4 ♥ 8 7 ♦ 8 5 3 ♣ K Q 5 2	N W E S	♠ K 8 3 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 9 6 4 2 ♣ 10 9 7 3
	♠ J 6 2 ♥ A K J 6 4 2 ♦ K ♣ J 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♠[2]	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 3 aces

6♥ by North
Lead: ♣10

Your partnership may play that a jump to 3♥ shows a 6-card suit with slam interest, in other words, this very hand. If you do, then bid it. If you don't, use a transfer first. Let's say you bid 2♦. Partner jumps to 3♥. Now

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least two Aces for his strong bidding. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and this is certainly not the type of hand where asking for Aces is always helpful - what if partner shows two Aces, aren't you going to bid the slam anyway? The advantage to Blackwood here is that there is just a slim possibility that partner has only one Ace!

You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♠. Next?

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The contract would be 6♥ played by South.

North plays 6♥. East leads the ♣10. You play the ♣J, just in case East made a mistake, but West puts on the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

The ♠ loser is deceptive. You could discard a ♠ from dummy on your ♦A, but would still have a ♠ loser if the finesse doesn't work. Still, this would be one possible plan. Can you improve on that?

Maybe you can. Look harder at the ♦s. Win the ♣A, then play to dummy's ♦K. Pull trumps (2 rounds) ending in your hand. Play your ♦A, but discard a ♣ from dummy, (the key play). Now play your ♦J, and if East plays low, discard dummy's other ♣.

You have gotten rid of the ♣ losers, but if West can win the ♦Q on this trick you will discard a ♠ on the ♦10, but will still have to try the ♠ finesse.

But, if the ♦J holds then it won't matter if the ♠ finesse works or not, you will make the slam.

Suppose when you play your ♦J East puts on the ♦Q.

Board 2
East Deals
None Vul

♠ K 6 3
♥ 7 4 2
♦ Q 10 9
♣ 8 5 4 2

♠ 10 8 7 4
♥ J 9
♦ 8 5 4 3
♣ K Q 10

♠ Q 9 5
♥ K Q 8 6 3
♦ K 6 2
♣ A 3

♠ A J 2
♥ A 10 5
♦ A J 7
♣ J 9 7 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	1NT
All Pass			

1NT by South
Lead: ♥J

With no reason to think you could improve the contract you just pass.

The contract would be 1NT played by North.

South plays 1NT. West leads the ♥J and East plays the ♥8. Do you hold up? If so, how many times?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

It probably makes no difference whether you hold up or not since East surely has most of the high cards. However, holding up once is a good idea because West may have a singleton ♥ and have to switch to something which helps you. West holds the first trick and plays another ♥, which you win.

You must find 4 winners. The bad news is that you must finesse both the ♦K and the ♠Q. The good news is that with East opening the bidding there is a good chance he has both of them. So, how will you manage those two finesses?

There is only one way to do it. Enter dummy with the only entry, the ♠K. Take the ♦ finesse first - play the ♦Q and unblock your ♦J when East plays low. (you could play the ♦10/♦7 combination first).

Finesse the ♦ again. If East ducks a second time you must now take the ♠ finesse while you are still in dummy. If East covers the second ♦ you win with your ♦A, return to dummy with the ♦9, and then finesse the ♠.

Having used dummy's lone entry to get there in the first place you have to make sure you take the finesse that permits you to either remain in dummy, or to return if East plays his King.

And you have to be careful to unblock so you don't inadvertently lose your place in dummy too soon.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K 4 ♥ A 7 4 ♦ K 10 7 4 ♣ A Q J 5	
♠ Q 9 8 2 ♥ 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 ♣ 8 7 6 4	N W E S	♠ J 10 6 ♥ Q J 10 9 8 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ K 2
	♠ A 7 5 3 ♥ K 6 ♦ Q J 5 2 ♣ 10 9 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

With no 4-card Major suit you respond 2♦ to partner's Stayman bid. Partner now bids 2NT.

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With 17 points you naturally accept partner's invitation and bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

East's ♥Q lead presents you with an immediate decision (or two) to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

You need 4 additional winners and can only establish 3 of them in ♦s. So you will have to manufacture another one from the ♣ suit as well. If you assume the ♣ finesse will fail, (and you have probably noticed that most finesses **DO** fail on these pages), that means you will lose the lead twice.

So what do you do about that ♥Q? Do you win or hold up?

You hold up, of course, to cut defensive communications when East has 5 ♥s and West has 3. East will probably play another ♥ to dummy's ♥K.

If both the ♦A and ♣K are in East's hand then you won't make this contract. He will easily establish his ♥s and have an entry to get in and cash them. If the ♦A is with East and the ♣K is with West then it doesn't matter in which order you play the suits since you will not lose the lead in ♣s. But if the ♣K is with East and the ♦A is with West then it is vital that you play ♣s first.

If you play on ♦s first, West will win the ♦A and play his last ♥, forcing out your ♥A. When East wins his ♣K he will cash 2 more ♥s.

But, if you finesse in ♣s first, East can win and establish the ♥ suit. But, when West wins the ♦A, he will have no ♥ to return.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K 7 3 ♥ K J 8 2 ♦ A Q J ♣ 9 8	
♠ 10 9 8 4 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 8 7 5 2 ♣ Q 10 3	N W E S	♠ Q 6 2 ♥ Q 6 5 ♦ 10 9 3 ♣ J 7 5 4
	♠ J 5 ♥ A 9 7 3 ♦ K 6 4 ♣ A K 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠10

Did you consider bidding 6NT? You are balanced, and the points are right. But with two 4-card Majors you should use Stayman, so you bid 2♣. Partner bids 2♥. Now what do say next?

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

Did you consider bidding 6NT? You are balanced, and the points are right. But with two 4-card Majors you should use Stayman, so you bid 2♣. Partner bids 2♥. Now what do say next?

You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

He has two Aces so you bid 6♥ because you know there aren't enough points for seven.

The contract would be 6♥ played by North.

South plays 6♥. West leads the ♠10.

You toy with the idea of letting this ride to your ♠J, then you put away your childish toys and play the ♠A from dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

The two ♣ losers can be ruffed in dummy. A successful ♥ finesse could save you a loser in trumps. So, should you take the ♥ finesse now?

No, because if you play ♥A, then the ♥ finesse **LOSES**, East might play a third ♥ and stop you from your two ruffs in dummy. A much better plan is to play the ♥K, then ♥A, and if the ♥Q drops, well and good. This time she doesn't, but both East and West follow to both trump leads. Play the ♣ A K, the ♠K, and the ♦ A K Q.

If somebody ruffs any of these it will be with the master trump and you won't care. But if they don't ruff yet, you just start cross-ruffing ♣s and ♠s and let them ruff in whenever they like.

Missing 5 trumps to the Queen the correct play to avoid a loser is to finesse.